

A LOOK AT TRUECRYPT

THE OPEN SOURCE SECURITY TOOL

The last article covered Tripwire, which ensures the integrity of the file system. This article extends the security from the operating system and application files a level further. Disk encryption is predominantly used in critical open source infrastructures, for which TrueCrypt is widely used.

In the past, the security of data residing on the disks was seldom a priority. This led to the situation in which data was only securely stored and accessed as long as the disk was in the system. Having physical access to remove the hard disk, however, could let the attacker gain complete access to the data by simply plugging in the drive as a secondary volume in another system. This problem was more serious for desktops, where systems could be easily moved between locations, thus resulting in possible data leakages. This called for a means of encrypting the data in such a way that even if the disks are moved to a different machine, the contents of the volume are protected, and accessible only to authenticated owners. This required a strong encryption system on the disk itself, with the necessary authentication services.